

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 812

By Watson

A RESOLUTION to recognize May 17 as Necrotizing Enterocolitis (NEC) Awareness Day in Tennessee.

WHEREAS, necrotizing enterocolitis (NEC) is the most common cause of death in hospitalized premature infants after two weeks of age; and

WHEREAS, babies born prematurely or with a medical complication, such as congenital heart disease, are most at risk of NEC; and

WHEREAS, thousands of babies develop NEC each year, and hundreds of babies die from this complex intestinal condition; and

WHEREAS, necrotizing enterocolitis causes a severe inflammatory process that can lead to intestinal tissue damage and death, and, after NEC is diagnosed, many babies only live for a few hours or days; and

WHEREAS, surgery for NEC is not curative, and the babies who survive often have lifelong neurological and nutritional complications; and

WHEREAS, necrotizing enterocolitis results in approximately \$5 billion of hospitalization expenses per year and roughly nineteen percent of neonatal healthcare expenditures in the United States, with an estimated cost of \$200,000 or more for each case of surgical necrotizing enterocolitis; and

WHEREAS, breast milk is one of the most effective ways to help prevent necrotizing enterocolitis in medically fragile infants, and when the mother's milk is unavailable, pasteurized donor human milk is the next-safest option for babies at risk of NEC; and

WHEREAS, formula does not protect against the risk of NEC in medically fragile infants; infants at risk of NEC receive the most protection from their mother's own milk and pasteurized donor human milk; and

WHEREAS, although the risk of necrotizing enterocolitis cannot be fully eliminated and there are not yet sure ways to stop or cure NEC, preventative measures are effective at reducing risks; and

WHEREAS, parents must be trusted and valued as the most important member of their baby's care team, and healthcare providers should partner with families to provide the best care for infants at risk of NEC; and

WHEREAS, necrotizing enterocolitis can develop in both premature babies and babies born at term, and more data is desperately needed to better understand how and why NEC occurs in preterm and term infants; and

WHEREAS, disparities and variation in care lead to Black infants being disproportionately affected by, and dying from, necrotizing enterocolitis compared to white infants; and

WHEREAS, the NEC Society is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization founded and led by a bereaved mother whose son died from complications of NEC, and the NEC Society is the world's leading charity working to accelerate NEC research, education, and advocacy; and

WHEREAS, to raise awareness, the NEC Society observes the month of May as NEC Awareness Month across the nation; and

WHEREAS, to build a world without necrotizing enterocolitis and improve outcomes for infants and families, it is vital that we raise awareness about this devastating neonatal disease; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that May 17 is recognized as Necrotizing Enterocolitis (NEC) Awareness Day in Tennessee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.